Jheeram Ghati, followed by 11 in 2011 and 10 in 2008, all during BJP rule. The Congress has been in power since December 2018 after which political murders have numbered a low 3, 4, 2, 1 and 2 in 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 respectively (the police recognise only two of the recent murders as 'political' in nature). "These incidents are unfortunate, but we need to understand the modus operandi of Naxals. Whenever they are on the back foot, they indulge in such incidents to create a fear psychosis across the region," says Sundarraj Pattilingam, inspector general of police, Bastar.

The Union government, meanwhile, has pledged additional security forces for Chhattisgarh, which are being deployed at newly opened camps in regions that were hitherto not accessible to the forces. Maoist releases have also spoken of a change in strategy by the forces—a new aggression that seems to have brought about a counter.

BAGHEL DISMISSES CONSPIRACY ANGLES AND SAYS THE BJP CAN HAND OVER ALL CASES TO CENTRAL PROBE AGENCIES

The spate of killings adds a complicating backdrop to the political tussle in Bastar. In the 2018 assembly election, the Congress had won 11 of the region's 12 seats. In a byelection, it also wrested Dantewada, which had fallen vacant after the murder of the lone BJP MLA, Mandavi. Since it stands at zero, the BJP naturally sees potential for growth here. Especially because most Baghel government's schemes target agrarian communities that dominate the central Chhattisgarhi landscape, the BJP has identified Bastar and the North, both tribal-dominated regions, as potential seat-harvesting areas. It will, however, need to work on cadre morale post the murders. ■

MAHARASHTRA

MAHA FIGHT IN CONGRESS



SEEDS OF RIFT Maharashtra Congress chief Nana Patole with senior leader Balasaheb Thorat

ANI

By Dhaval Kulkarni

For a party that was seen as lacking the spunk to take on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Nana Patole's appointment as president of the Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee (MPCC) in February 2021 was expected to pump some belligerence into the Grand Old Party's rank and file in the western state. Patole's aggression was his USP, along with his background as a leader of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs). Theoretically sound, the move did not translate particularly well into practice. Two years later, Patole's style of leadership is being called "authoritarian" by his detractors and has caused quite a churn within the state Congress.

The simmering discontent burst into the public domain when Congress Legislature Party (CLP) president Balasaheb Thorat stepped down from his position on February 7. Thorat is an eight-term MLA, a former revenue minister in the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) coalition, and a member of the Congress Working Committee (CWC). His move came after his nephew and former Maharashtra Youth Congress president Satyajeet Tambe rebelled against the party to contest the state legislative council polls as an independent from the Nashik graduates' constituency. Tambe alleged that powers